Geopolitics has broken shipping with 2027 outlook just as bleak

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At no point in modern history have there been as many attacks against civilian ships as in 2026, and the outlook is no better for 2027, as both the Ukraine and Middle East wars are likely to continue.
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Record-high tanker freight rates and war-risk insurance premiums will keep delivered energy costs high into 2027, while container rates—which matter most for consumer goods—have risen much more modestly.
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Higher energy and freight costs will likely squeeze energy-intensive industries and add to inflation, further denting already tepid consumer sentiment, even as overall manufacturing output holds up.

Geopolitical conflict has broken key maritime trade links, with attacks on ships surging. At no point in modern history have there been as many attacks against civilian ships as in 2026, which has seen hundreds of serious and targeted state-orchestrated attacks with dozens of crew fatalities.

In the Middle East, more than 130 attacks against civilian maritime merchants were reported between 28 February (the start of the US/Iran war) and 20 October 2026 to the UK Maritime Trade Operations (UKMTO) Centre, which monitors naval security around the Arabian Peninsula. Iran and its Houthi allies have carried out most of these attacks in the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab al-Mandeb. The true number is almost certainly higher, as not all attacks are reported.

In the Black Sea, almost 100 attacks have been recorded, with Ukraine targeting tankers carrying Russian oil and Russia targeting both Ukrainian grain export vessels and tankers carrying fuel into Ukraine. This is also likely to be a significant undercount, since there is no central body for that region comparable to the UKMTO to monitor such developments.

By the end of 2026, it’s likely 300 attacks will have occurred, according to Eurasia Group estimates based on information from shippers, Kpler ship-tracking data, and maritime bodies such as the International Maritime Organization (IMO). That would be as many attacks in one year as the total reported since 1990. It would also be almost as many attacks as were reported during the so-called Tanker Wars from 1981–1988.

The outlook for 2027 is no better, with potential for further deterioration. Neither the war in the Middle East nor the conflict in Ukraine is likely to be resolved in the coming months (see: Hormuz attacks likely

to compel US escalation after midterms , 15 October 2026; and: Ukraine will absorb US pressure and keep hitting refineries , 15 October 2026).

Both conflicts could escalate and spill into more maritime regions, including the Baltic Sea, the North Sea, or the Arctic.

These disruptions will exact a significant economic toll, particularly for the energy sector. Between 80% and 90% of all global goods are traded by ship, and the high risk to shipping has caused a spike in freight rates. War-risk insurance for Gulf tankers has jumped to 6%-10% of hull value (equivalent to as much as $20 million for a single voyage), from about 0.25% before the war.

The energy sector is being hit especially hard. Freight costs for a Very Large Crude Carrier (VLCC)—capable of carrying 2 million barrels of oil—now add between $20-$40 per barrel to the already high cost of transporting crude oil from the Middle East to customers in Asia or Europe. Before the war, this stood at $2 a barrel.

Container rates, which matter most for consumer goods, have also risen, albeit less dramatically. Drewry's global container index has more than doubled since February.

Freight will add to inflation at the margin, while energy does most of the damage. Freight and insurance made up about 5% of the value of imported goods before the war, against more than a quarter for Gulf crude currently shipped to Asia. The IMF estimated the larger 2021 freight spike added about 1.5 percentage points to 2022 inflation. In the US, higher freight costs have yet to reach consumer goods prices. The IMF's adverse scenario, with Hormuz and the Bab al-Mandeb largely closed through June 2027 and oil at $130, would add about one percentage point to global inflation in 2027.

Energy-intensive industries in fuel-import-dependent regions will see output cuts. The high natural gas costs in Asia and Europe, driven by the Middle East disruptions, have pushed wholesale power prices as high as $300 per megawatt-hour (MWh) in some regions—triple the pre-war levels. That's prohibitively expensive; a cost below $80/MWh is generally seen as necessary for energy-intensive industries in Asia and Europe to be cost-competitive in global markets.

Yet overall, manufacturing is holding up. Global factory output is growing at its fastest pace since July 2021. Inventory building and substitution effects have protected output so far (as have improvements to energy efficiency over the past five years). However, that buffer will thin if disruptions last, as this inflationary pressure will dent already tepid consumer sentiment.

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